



AFP

LEADER ON THE RADAR

Red Bull faces a massive threat to its stranglehold over the championship, as McLaren, Ferrari and Mercedes **inch closer to the top** of the standings.

Dipak Ragav

dipak.ragav@thehindu.co.in

After a four-week break, the Formula One bandwagon regrouped at Zandvoort for the Dutch Grand Prix. Since its return to the F1 calendar in 2021, the Dutch GP has been one big party, coinciding with the rise of its local hero, Max Verstappen.

The reigning three-time champion had won all three previous races on home soil in dominant fashion. However, heading into this year's race, expectations weren't as high, as Red Bull had been struggling lately against McLaren and Mercedes. The big question ahead of the

championship's resumption was where would Red Bull rank in light of McLaren's surge.

Orange rules, but not the Dutch variety

Since the start of the Verstappen era, Dutch fans have painted every F1 race track around the world in their national colour of orange. Sunday at Zandvoort was no different. However, for the first time since the return of F1 to the Netherlands, Verstappen found himself on the back foot when Lando Norris (**above**) took pole position, setting a time more than three-tenths faster than the Red Bull driver.

When the race started, Verstappen got the crowd on their feet when he pipped Norris at